countries for seeking vacancies for courses of instruction in our armed forces training institutions.

Joint exercises between two armed forces are designed to evolve common operating procedures that could be used during the conduct of counterterrorist or peacekeeping operations and disaster management. They could also be designed to counter emerging threats such as the use of weapons of mass destruction. Such exercises are mutually beneficial to both sides as they help to develop better understanding and improve interoperability. Military training exchanges, both bilateral and multilateral, are an important component of military diplomacy and a valuable instrument of building bridges between armed forces, with the purpose of promoting national interests. These activities comprise conduct of professional courses, making available of training advisers, and provision of training teams. It may be recalled that we raised the military academies in Ethiopia and Nigeria and our officers helped to run these training institutions for a number of years. Similarly we had air force training teams in Egypt and Iraq, which trained a whole generation of pilots from these Arab countries.

When I visited Nigeria as the chief of army staff, a brigadier at their Kaduna academy remarked that on seeing my olive green uniform his hair stood on end, as he was reminded of his Indian Army instructors. In a meeting during that visit, when I pointed out that their president, General Obasanjo, was an illustrious and distinguished alumnus of the Defence Services Staff College in India, the president remarked, ‘Gentlemen, have you heard what the Indian army chief has just said.’ Similarly, King Jigme Khesar Namgyel Wangchuk, the present king of Bhutan, and General Irshad, the former president of Bangladesh, are graduates of the National Defence College, New Delhi. There have been at least six chiefs of armed forces of countries like Sri Lanka, Nigeria, Malaysia and Afghanistan who have graduated from the National Defence College in India. It is but natural that such training programmes generate a lot of goodwill and bonhomie which, if nurtured, could prove to be a great asset while dealing with these countries.